

A STEP-BY-STEP PROMPT PLAYBOOK

Market Research AI Prompt Framework

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Written during my time at the accelerator

Overview

I built this framework while working as a Data Analyst at Genesis Accelerator, where I ran market research together with the founders in the program. It turns a startup's website and the public conversations of its customers into research you can act on: real customer language, a competitor map, messaging tables, a market size estimate and ready-to-use copy.

This edition reflects what I learned since. AI tools now browse and run deep research on their own, which makes them much faster and also makes invented quotes harder to spot. So every step now demands sources, separates evidence from inference, and passes its output to the next step. The result is research you can defend in front of a customer, a product team or an investor.

Who this is for

Founders

Know your customer before you build, and pitch investors with evidence instead of assumptions.

Analysts

Run a structured, repeatable research process in hours instead of weeks, with every claim traceable.

Marketers

Write copy, ads and landing pages that sound like they came from inside the community.

What you walk away with

- Customer quotes with links
- Persona sketch
- Competitor map
- Awareness and desire tables
- Feature-to-benefit ranking
- TAM / SAM / SOM
- Positioning and copy

START HERE

How the framework works

Eight steps, run in order. Each one takes the outputs of the steps before it, so the research builds on itself instead of starting over every time.



> The **Research Brief** from Step 1 is pasted into every later step. Step 6 is optional, and most useful before an investor deck.

Quick reference

STEP	NAME	WHAT YOU GET	BROWSING	TIME
1	Research Brief	Research Brief (save it, you will paste it into every later step)	Yes	15 min
2	Voice of Customer	Voice of Customer file: quotes by category and theme, persona sketch, gaps	Yes	30-60 min
3	Competitor Landscape	Competitor table, review complaints, positioning gaps	Yes	30 min
4	Awareness Levels and Desires	Awareness table, desire ladder table, Will / Won't / Can't Tell table	No	15 min
5	Feature-to-Benefit Ladder	Ranked feature table, lead features, orphan features	Yes	15 min
6	Market Sizing Sanity Check	Assumptions table, TAM / SAM / SOM with formulas, sensitivity check	Yes	20 min
7	Validate	Quote audit, evidence ratings, five customer conversations	Partly	1-2 days incl. calls
8	Build Assets	Positioning statement, message house, headlines, pitch slide	No	15 min

Before you start

- [ ] The company website and, if you know them, 2 to 3 competitor sites.
- [ ] An AI tool with web browsing and a deep research mode (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Perplexity all work).
- [ ] One working document where you save each step's output under its step name.
- [ ] A list of places your customers actually talk (see the next page).

START HERE

Three rules behind every prompt

They are already written into each prompt. Knowing why they are there helps you spot when a result breaks them.

1. **Real or nothing.** Every quote needs a working link. AI models will happily invent believable quotes to reach a target number, so there are no quotas. Ten real quotes beat a hundred invented ones.

2. **Label inference.** Anything the model concludes rather than finds is tagged [Inference]. Facts and guesses both have value, but you should always know which one you are looking at.

3. **Say what is missing.** Every output ends with its gaps and weak spots. A research file that admits what it does not know is one you can trust with the rest.

Choose sources that fit your market

Reddit is a great source for US consumer and tech audiences, but it skews young, male, American and English-speaking. Pick sources where your actual customers spend time and paste them into the [SOURCES] slot of Step 2.

YOUR MARKET	WHERE TO LOOK
B2B software	G2, Capterra and TrustRadius reviews, public industry forums, LinkedIn*
Consumer products	Amazon reviews of competitor products, Reddit, TikTok and YouTube comments
Mobile apps	App Store and Google Play reviews of competing apps, Reddit
Local or Israeli market	Local forums, Google Maps reviews, Hebrew YouTube comments, Hebrew Facebook groups*
Professional services	Niche professional forums, Google reviews, Quora, LinkedIn*

* Private Facebook groups and LinkedIn sit behind a login, so AI tools usually cannot read them. Collect those posts yourself and paste them into the "Material I collected myself" slot of Step 2. Quotes stay in their original language, with an English translation added.

Working tips

Save the brief once. If your tool supports Projects or custom instructions, store the Research Brief there instead of pasting it into every prompt.

Fill every bracket. Text in [BRACKETS] is yours to replace. Leaving one empty is the most common reason a step returns generic results.

Keep one file. When all steps are done, upload the full file to a fresh AI session and keep asking it questions. It becomes a research assistant that knows your market.

STEP 1 OF 8

1 Research Brief

Builds the one-page brief that every later step reads. It answers three questions: who we target, what we sell, and which problems we solve.

TIME
15 min

WEB BROWSING
Yes

YOU PASTE IN
Company website, up to 3 competitor sites, what you already believe

YOU GET
Research Brief (save it, you will paste it into every later step)

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a strategy analyst preparing a research brief for a market research project.

# Goal
Write a short brief that answers three questions: who we are targeting, what we are selling, and what
problems we solve. Later research steps will use this brief as their only context, so it must be accurate
and specific.

# Inputs
Company website: [URL]
Competitor websites (optional, up to 3): [URLs]
What I already believe (optional):
- Ideal customer: [TEXT or "unknown"]
- Product: [TEXT or "unknown"]
- Problems it solves: [TEXT or "unknown"]
Target geography and language: [e.g. US English, Israel Hebrew]

# Task
1. Read the company website and any competitor sites provided.
2. If something critical is missing and you cannot infer it from the sites, ask me up to 3 short questions
before writing. Otherwise go straight to the brief.
3. Write the brief in plain language. Avoid marketing claims you cannot trace to the site.
4. Where my beliefs differ from what the website says, point out the difference rather than picking one.

# Output
Return exactly these sections:
IDEAL CUSTOMER: one paragraph on who they are, their situation, and what they want.
PRODUCT: one or two sentences on what it is and how it is positioned.
PROBLEMS: two to four problems the product solves, one sentence each.
COMPETITORS NAMED: the competitors you found or were given.
GEOGRAPHY AND LANGUAGE: as given.
OPEN QUESTIONS: anything unclear or contradictory.

Write in prose inside each section. Do not invent facts that are not on the sites or in my inputs.
```

Tip. If you already know the answers, fill them in and let the model check them against the website. Disagreements between your view and the site are often the most useful finding of the whole project.

STEP 2 OF 8

2 Voice of Customer

Collects real quotes, with links, from people who match your ideal customer, and builds the persona only from what they said.

TIME 30-60 min	**WEB BROWSING** Yes (deep research mode)
YOU PASTE IN Research Brief, list of sources where your customers talk	**YOU GET** Voice of Customer file: quotes by category and theme, persona sketch, gaps

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a voice-of-customer researcher. Your job is to find what real people say, in their own words, and never to write words for them.

# Goal
Collect verbatim quotes from people who match the ideal customer, grouped by theme, so that later messaging uses the market's own language.

# Research Brief
[PASTE RESEARCH BRIEF]

# Sources
Search these places first: [SOURCES, e.g. r/xyz, a G2 category page, Amazon reviews of competitor products, public forums]
You may add other public sources where this audience talks. Prefer posts from the last 12 months. Today's date is [DATE].

# Material I collected myself (optional)
[PASTE POSTS FROM PRIVATE GROUPS OR LOGIN-ONLY SITES, each with its link]

# Task
1. List the sources you searched and roughly how much relevant material each had.
2. Collect quotes in these six categories:
   Identity: how they describe themselves and their situation
   Fears: what they worry will happen
   Frustrations: what annoys them now, including current solutions
   Desires: what they want to have or become
   Beliefs: what they think is true about the problem or the market
   Obstacles: what stops them from getting what they want
3. Inside each category, group quotes into themes. Under each theme write one Note line that sums up the pattern.
4. Write a five-to-six sentence persona sketch built only from the quotes.

# Rules
- Copy every quote exactly as written, including slang, typos and punctuation.
- Keep quotes in their original language. If a quote is not in English, add an English translation in brackets after it.
- Every quote needs a direct link to the post or review, plus its date. Drop any quote without a link.
- Do not paraphrase, merge or tidy quotes. A summary is a Note, not a quote.
- There is no quota. Aim for 8 to 15 quotes per category, but stop when real material runs out and say so.
- If a category has fewer than 3 real quotes, write "Thin evidence" under it instead of filling it.

# Output
SOURCES SEARCHED: a short list.
Per category, each theme as: Theme: [name] / "Exact quote" (source, date, link) / Note: [pattern]
PERSONA SKETCH: five to six sentences.
GAPS: thin categories, sources you could not access, and audiences these sources may miss.
```

Tip. Run it in two different research tools and merge the results. A quote both tools found is one you can trust.

STEP 3 OF 8

3 Competitor Landscape

Maps the alternatives your customer actually chooses today, including doing nothing, and finds the gaps no one covers well.

TIME	**WEB BROWSING**
30 min	Yes
YOU PASTE IN	**YOU GET**
Research Brief, Frustrations and Obstacles from Step 2, known competitors	Competitor table, review complaints, positioning gaps

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a competitive intelligence analyst.

# Goal
Map the alternatives our ideal customer uses today and find the gaps we can win on.

# Research Brief
[PASTE RESEARCH BRIEF]

# Voice of Customer (Frustrations and Obstacles only)
[PASTE FROM STEP 2]

# Known competitors
[LIST, or "find them"]

# Task
1. Identify up to 8 alternatives in three groups: direct competitors, indirect substitutes (a different kind of solution to the same problem), and the do-nothing or DIY option.
2. For each alternative, read its website, pricing page and public reviews.
3. Fill the table below. Every price needs a link and the date you saw it.
4. From reviews, collect up to 3 complaints per competitor, quoted exactly, with links.
5. Compare these complaints with our customers' frustrations and name the gaps no competitor covers well.

# Rules
- If pricing is not public, write "Not public". Do not estimate.
- Mark any judgement that is not a direct fact as [Inference].

# Output
COMPETITOR TABLE:
| Name | Type (direct / substitute / DIY) | Target customer | Core promise (their words) | Pricing (link, date) | Main strength | Main complaint |

REVIEW COMPLAINTS: per competitor, quotes with links.
POSITIONING GAPS: three to five gaps, each with its evidence and a confidence of High, Medium or Low.
GAPS IN THIS RESEARCH: what you could not find.
```

Tip. The most dangerous competitor is often the spreadsheet, the agency or the habit your customer already has. Do not skip the DIY row.

STEP 4 OF 8

4 Awareness Levels and Desires

Applies Eugene Schwartz's five awareness levels and a "so I can" ladder to the evidence you collected. Hidden motives are labeled as inference, not passed off as findings.

TIME	**WEB BROWSING**
15 min	No
YOU PASTE IN	**YOU GET**
Research Brief, Step 2 output, positioning gaps from Step 3	Awareness table, desire ladder table, Will / Won't / Can't Tell table

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a direct-response strategist who works with Eugene Schwartz's market awareness levels.

# Goal
Turn the voice-of-customer evidence into tables a copywriter can use directly.

# Research Brief
[PASTE RESEARCH BRIEF]

# Evidence
Voice of Customer: [PASTE STEP 2 OUTPUT]
Positioning gaps: [PASTE FROM STEP 3]

# Task
1. Awareness levels. For each of the five levels (Unaware, Problem Aware, Solution Aware, Product Aware,
Most Aware), list three to five questions a prospect at that level is asking. Use phrasing from the
evidence wherever possible.
2. Desire ladders. Pick the five to eight strongest desires in the evidence. For each, ask "so I can..."
three times to reach the deeper motive.
3. Will Tell / Won't Tell / Can't Tell. For each desire, describe what people say openly, what they likely
keep private, and what drives them without their noticing.

# Rules
- Tag every cell [Quote] if it uses wording from the evidence, or [Inference] if it is your reasoning.
Won't Tell and Can't Tell are almost always [Inference].
- For [Quote] cells, include the link from the evidence.
- Use only the evidence provided. Do not search for new sources.

# Output
AWARENESS TABLE:
| Level | Questions the prospect asks | Tag |

DESIRE LADDER TABLE:
| Desire | So I can (1) | So I can (2) | So I can (3) |

WILL / WON'T / CAN'T TELL TABLE:
| Desire | Will Tell | Won't Tell | Can't Tell |

WEAK SPOTS: desires or levels supported by little evidence.
Format tables so they paste into a spreadsheet with no cleanup.
```

Tip. Use the awareness table to decide where each asset speaks. A cold ad talks to Problem Aware people; a pricing page talks to Product Aware ones. Mixing the two is the most common reason copy feels off.

STEP 5 OF 8

5 Feature-to-Benefit Ladder

Translates every real product feature into benefits and ties each one to a proven customer desire. Shows which features to lead with and which ones the market does not care about.

TIME
15 min

WEB BROWSING
Yes

YOU PASTE IN
Research Brief, product pages, desire ladder table from Step 4

YOU GET
Ranked feature table, lead features, orphan features

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a product marketer who translates features into benefits customers care about.

# Goal
Build a table that runs from each real product feature to the customer desire it serves, and flag features that serve no proven desire.

# Research Brief
[PASTE RESEARCH BRIEF]

# Product sources
[URLs of product pages, docs, spec sheets, demo videos]

# Desires from Step 4
[PASTE DESIRE LADDER TABLE]

# Task
1. Read the product sources and list every concrete feature in the product's own wording. Add no benefit language yet.
2. For each feature, fill the ladder:
   a. Why it exists, in plain language
   b. Benefit: "so you can..."
   c. Benefit of the benefit: "so you can..." again
   d. Dominant emotion when that payoff is reached
   e. Matching desire from Step 4, or "None found"
3. Rank the features by how strongly they connect to desires with solid evidence.

# Rules
- Never invent specs. If a detail is unclear, write "Unclear" and link the page you checked.
- A feature that maps to "None found" is a finding, not a failure. Keep it in the table.

# Output
| Rank | Feature | Why it exists | Benefit (so you can...) | Benefit of the benefit | Dominant emotion | Matching desire | Source link |

LEAD FEATURES: the top three to lead messaging with, and why.
ORPHAN FEATURES: features with no matching desire.
```

Tip. Orphan features are a gift for the product team. A feature nobody desires is either badly explained or not worth building further, and both are worth knowing.

STEP 6 OF 8 OPTIONAL

6 Market Sizing Sanity Check

Builds a bottom-up TAM, SAM and SOM with every assumption visible, so a founder can defend the number in front of investors or replace weak inputs with better data.

TIME	WEB BROWSING
20 min	Yes
YOU PASTE IN	**YOU GET**
Research Brief, competitor table from Step 3, your expected price	Assumptions table, TAM / SAM / SOM with formulas, sensitivity check

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a startup analyst who builds bottom-up market estimates and shows every assumption.

# Goal
Estimate TAM, SAM and SOM for this product in [GEOGRAPHY], with every input sourced or clearly marked as an assumption.

# Research Brief
[PASTE RESEARCH BRIEF]

# Pricing context from Step 3
[PASTE COMPETITOR TABLE]

# Our expected price
[PRICE AND BILLING UNIT, or "use the competitor median"]

# Task
1. Define the countable customer unit (for example, companies with 10 to 200 employees in sector X, or households with children under 5).
2. Find how many such units exist, citing a source with a link and year.
3. Build the estimate bottom up:
   TAM = all units × annual price
   SAM = units we can realistically reach with our channel and geography × annual price
   SOM = SAM × a plausible 3-year share, justified by comparable companies
4. Find one published top-down figure for this market and compare it with your result.
5. Sensitivity: show SOM with the two weakest assumptions at half and at double their values.

# Rules
- Every number is either [Sourced] with a link and year, or [Assumption] with a one-line reason.
- If the top-down and bottom-up figures differ by more than 3x, explain the likely reason. Do not force them to match.

# Output
ASSUMPTIONS TABLE:
| Input | Value | Unit | Sourced or Assumption | Link or reason |

RESULT: TAM, SAM and SOM in [CURRENCY] per year, with formulas shown.
TOP-DOWN COMPARISON: the published figure, its link, and the gap.
SENSITIVITY: SOM in the low and high cases.
WEAKEST ASSUMPTIONS: the two inputs to verify first.
```

Tip. Investors trust a small, well-argued bottom-up number far more than a huge top-down one from a market report. Lead with the bottom-up figure and use the report only as a cross-check.

STEP 7 OF 8

7 Validate Before You Use It

A second AI can catch weak reasoning, but it cannot confirm that a quote or a number is real. So validation has three layers, and the first one is done by hand.

7a. Quote audit by hand, about 20 minutes

Open 10 random quote links from Step 2 and 5 from Step 3. For each, check that the post exists, the wording matches exactly, and the author plausibly fits the persona.

LINK	EXISTS	WORDING MATCHES	FITS PERSONA

If more than 2 of the 15 fail, treat the whole quote set as unreliable and rerun Step 2 with a different tool or narrower sources.

7b. Cross-model critique

Open a fresh session in a different AI tool than the one you used for the research, paste the full file, and run:

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a skeptical research reviewer. Your job is to find what is wrong or unsupported, not to praise.

# Material
[PASTE FULL RESEARCH FILE]

# Task
1. List the five claims in this file that a decision would rest on most heavily.
2. For each, rate the evidence as Strong, Moderate or Weak, and say why.
3. Find contradictions between steps (for example, a desire in Step 4 that the Step 2 quotes do not support).
4. Name customer segments or sources the research likely missed, given the sources used.
5. Give one alternative interpretation of the customer's core problem that fits the same evidence.

# Rules
Be specific: name the step and the item. Skip generic advice such as "do more research".

# Output
KEY CLAIMS TABLE: | Claim | Step | Evidence rating | Reason |
CONTRADICTIONS
MISSING SEGMENTS OR SOURCES
ALTERNATIVE INTERPRETATION
```

7c. Five customer conversations

Take the claims rated Weak in 7b and the top three positioning gaps from Step 3. Turn them into open questions and talk to five people who match the persona. Where the conversations contradict the AI research, believe the conversations and update the file.

STEP 8 OF 8

8 Turn Research into Assets

The payoff. Turns the validated file into positioning, copy and pitch material, with every line tied back to the evidence behind it.

TIME 15 min	**WEB BROWSING** No
YOU PASTE IN The full validated research file and the assets you need	**YOU GET** Positioning statement, message house, headlines, ad angles, investor slide

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a positioning strategist and senior copywriter.

# Goal
Turn the validated research into ready-to-use messaging, with every line traceable to evidence.

# Validated research file
[PASTE FULL RESEARCH FILE, including your Step 7 notes]

# What I need
[CHOOSE: positioning statement, message house, homepage hero, ad angles, investor problem slide, sales email]

# Task
1. Positioning statement: For [who], who [struggle in their words], [product] is the [category] that [key benefit]. Unlike [main alternative], it [main difference].
2. Message house: one core message, three supporting pillars, and two proof points under each pillar.
3. Homepage hero: three headline and subheadline pairs, each written for a different awareness level from Step 4. Say which level each one targets.
4. Ad angles: five angles, each built on one fear, frustration or desire from Step 2.
5. Investor problem slide: three bullets on the problem and one on why now, using the strongest quotes and the Step 6 numbers if available.
6. Produce only the items I chose above.

# Rules
- After every line, add the evidence it rests on in brackets: the step, and a quote or data point.
- Reuse the customer's own words where they are stronger than yours.
- No hype words such as revolutionary, seamless, cutting-edge or game-changing.
- If the evidence does not support a claim, leave it out and tell me what is missing.

# Output
Each chosen item under its own heading, with evidence notes after each line.
```

Tip. The evidence notes are for you, not for publishing. Delete them before the copy goes live, but keep the annotated version. When someone asks "why did we say that?", you will have the answer.

SHORT ON TIME

Quick Version: One Prompt

A single prompt for a research agent that runs a condensed Steps 1 to 5 and 8 in one session. Use it for a first look at a market, a quick pre-meeting brief, or to decide whether the full framework is worth running.

TIME
20-30 min

WEB BROWSING
Yes (deep research or agent mode)

STRENGTHS
Fast, no copy-paste between steps, good enough for a first read

TRADE-OFFS
Fewer quotes, no market sizing, no validation layer, less control over each stage

Prompt copy everything inside this box

```
# Role
You are a market research analyst working for an early-stage startup. You find what real customers say and never write words for them.

# Goal
Produce a one-session market research report: who the customer is, what they say in their own words, who we compete with, and what we should lead with.

# Inputs
Company website: [URL]
Known competitors (optional): [NAMES OR URLs]
Target geography and language: [e.g. US English, Israel Hebrew]
Where our customers talk: [SOURCES, e.g. subreddits, G2 category, Amazon reviews, app store pages]
Today's date: [DATE]

# Task
Work through these stages in order and use what you learn in each one in the next.
1. Brief: from the website, describe the ideal customer, the product and the problems it solves.
2. Voice of customer: search the sources above and collect verbatim quotes in four categories: Fears, Frustrations, Desires, Obstacles. Aim for 5 to 8 per category.
3. Competitors: identify up to 5 alternatives, including the do-nothing option, with their core promise, pricing and main complaint from reviews.
4. Messaging: list the five strongest desires, ladder each one with "so I can..." twice, and match the product's top features to them.
5. Positioning: write one positioning statement and three homepage headline options.

# Rules
- Copy every quote exactly, with a direct link and date. Drop any quote you cannot link.
- Keep quotes in their original language and add an English translation in brackets if needed.
- No quotas. If evidence runs thin, write "Thin evidence" and move on.
- Never invent prices or product specs. Write "Not public" or "Unclear".
- Tag anything you conclude rather than find as [Inference].

# Output
BRIEF (one short paragraph per item)
VOICE OF CUSTOMER (quotes by category, each with source, date and link)
COMPETITOR TABLE: | Name | Type | Core promise | Pricing (link) | Main complaint |
DESIRES AND FEATURES TABLE: | Desire | So I can | So I can | Matching feature |
POSITIONING STATEMENT AND HEADLINES
GAPS: what this report could not verify, and what to check by hand before using it
```

Tip. Treat the quick report as a hypothesis. Before it goes into a deck or a product decision, open five of its links and run Step 7.

About



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I developed this framework while working with early-stage founders at Genesis Accelerator, and refined it based on how it held up in real projects. Feel free to use it, adapt it and share it.

Credits

The awareness levels and desire work draw on Eugene Schwartz, *Breakthrough Advertising* (1966). The verbatim quote harvest adapts a voice-of-customer prompt pattern widely shared in marketing communities. The step chaining, competitor and sizing steps, evidence tagging, validation layers and asset step are original to this framework.